



RPI Outdoor Programs and Rensselaer Outing Club

Indoor Rock Wall Policies

Introduction:

Indoor Rock Climbing (bouldering) has the potential to be a dangerous activity. Due to this inherent danger, the conduct of this activity's leaders and participants must fall under the accepted scope of practice for Indoor Rock Climbing at RPI.

This document intends to standardize Indoor Rock Climbing in the 87' Gym Rock Wall and will outline the guidelines and standards for which Outdoor Programs Employees and Wall Leaders are permitted to operate. These guidelines and standards meet or exceed industry standards and best practices commonly accepted by professional practitioners throughout the greater outdoor education and recreation industry.

Rock Wall employees and leaders are approved using the standards outlined in this document, including guidelines of conduct and the organization's accepted scope of practice. Components of this document incorporate leading industry practices, years of combined experience, and the organization's culture/legacy in high consideration.

This document is organized by Program Overview and Guiding Principles, General Program Policies, Climbing Time Designations, Employee/Leader Qualifications, and Proper Documentation.

Program Overview and Guiding Principles:

RPI Outdoor Programs maintains an indoor rock climbing (bouldering) space within the '87 Gym located at 1145 Sage Ave, Troy, NY. The wall is designed to allow students, faculty, and other members of the RPI Community to climb in a controlled space during regularly scheduled hours. The space is operated by Outdoor Program (OP) employees during Open Hours and ROC Wall Leaders during Club Hours and Climbing Team Hours. The wall is designed for ropeless climbing with fall protection coming from spotting techniques and

flooring pads/crash pads. The 87' Gym Rock Wall is designed to offer challenges appropriate for all levels of climbing abilities.

Role of the Leaders:

- Outdoor Program Rock Wall Employees (OP Employees) are paid positions who have been hired and trained through RPI Outdoor Programs. They must attend at least one staff training per semester to maintain their role as an OP Employee. An Outdoor Program Rock Wall Employee must meet the minimum requirements outlined in the Employee/Leader Qualifications section of this document.
- A Rensselaer Outing Club's Wall Leader (Wall Leader) is a member of the Outing Club who wishes to facilitate climbing hours exclusively for club members. Wall Leaders are approved by ROC Ecomm and must meet the minimum requirements outlined in the Employee/Leader Qualifications section of this document.
- When hosting climbing hours at the rock wall, staff need to greet/orient participants, enforce rules/policies, and monitor unwarranted risks to the participants, leaders, equipment, and institution.
- OP Employees and Wall Leaders must adhere to the policies and standards that provide the framework for the experience; this includes working within the accepted scope of practice.
- OP Employees and Wall Leaders will act professionally while considering the needs of the participants.

Risk Management:

- OP Employees, Wall Leaders, and climbers will prioritize risk management before, during, and following climbing hours.
- Numerous factors contribute to the overall safety of all who are involved in the experience. It is expected that OP Employees and Wall Leaders will identify and anticipate these risks and make efforts to prevent participants from being exposed to those risks.
- At no point can all risk factors be eliminated. However, OP Employees and Wall Leaders must communicate the inherent risks involved with the activity to participants.

Etiquette:

- All leaders and participants will abide by Challenge by Choice and Full Value Contract practices.
- OP Employees and Wall Leaders will not discriminate or show priority to one patron over another.
- Remain out of the way of active climbers on the wall or in the path of their descent.

- Provide spotting for those who ask for it.
- Do not give out advice (or beta) without the consent of the receiving climber.
- If not climbing, make space for those who want to get on the wall. Do not monopolize a section of the wall for an extended period.
- If the wall reaches its capacity, the climbers who have been there the longest should leave to make space for more climbers.

General Program Policies:

- No roped climbing is allowed in the gym.
- Dynos, inversions, gymnastics, and other dangerous movements are not to be used.
- OP Employees and Wall leaders must abide by the Guiding Principles mentioned above.
- No one may be under the influence of drugs or alcohol when at the wall.
- Two Wall Leaders or Outdoor Program Rock Wall Employees must be present at the wall before any climbing takes place (Open Hours, Club Hours, etc.).
- OP Employees and Wall Leaders have the obligation to ask climbers to leave if they are not in compliance with Indoor Rock Wall Policies or rules.
- All climbers must sign in before they begin to climb.
- Only 6 people may climb at one time.
- The capacity of the space is limited to 15 people at a time. This includes all climbers, staff, spotters, and spectators.
- New routes must be approved by OP Employees or Wall Leaders before they can be climbed.
- Only OP Employees, Wall Leaders, and supervised route setters may install/uninstall climbing holds to the wall.
- Only OP Employees, Wall Leaders, or supervised route setters may access storage areas or the top of the wall structure.
- Climbers must be always protected by a spotter and crash pad when climbing on the wall.
- Routes may not be set over the doorway.
- Climbers may not “top out” to the top of the climbing wall.
- No climbing above or below another climber.
- All OP Employees and Wall Leaders must be aware and comply with all Opening & Closing procedures directed by OP Professional Staff.

Climbing Time Designations:

Open Climb:

Time designated as Open Climb is focused on serving the entire RPI community who wish to climb at the 87' Gym Rock Wall. OP Employees are responsible for providing orientation, risk management, enforcing capacity limits, and providing climbing guidance for patrons during Open Climb. Climbers at this time are not required to be affiliated with a specific club, intramural, or team to participate in Open Climb. Outing club members are suggested to climb at different times to provide space for others to climb during Open Climb.

Club Hours:

Club hours are time set aside for members of the Outing Club to utilize the rock wall exclusively. Climbers must be registered members of the Outing Club to use the 87' Gym Rock Wall during these times. Club Hours are facilitated by Outing Club Wall Leaders who have met the requirements of leadership and have been approved by the Outing Club's Ecomm.

Casual Climbing Practice:

This is time set aside for Outing Club members who wish to improve their climbing abilities and participate in more structured climbing activities. Climbing drills, exercises, and techniques are areas of focus during Casual Climbing Practice.

Employee/Leader Qualifications:

The following requirements are for both OP Employees and Wall Leaders.

- At least 18 years of age
- Current CPR & WFA/Basic First Aid certification.
- Knowledge of 87' Gym Emergency/Accident Protocols.
- Ability to follow and enforce RPI Outdoor Programs and Rensselaer Outing Club Indoor Rock Wall policies and procedures.
- An understanding of general climbing principles and climbing techniques.
- Ability to identify and anticipate risks common to indoor rock climbing.
- Has the physical ability to provide spotting for a climber.
- Is friendly, approachable, and willing to provide support to climbers at the wall.

The following requirements are for OP Employees only.

- Must attend at least one Outdoor Programs Rock Wall Employee staff training per semester.
- OP Employees must be registered to any group chat or message board identified by OP professional Staff.
- Must be enrolled in RPI Self-Service Information Systems before starting work.

The following requirements are for ROC Wall Leaders Only:

- Wall Leaders must provide a minimum of 1 hour a week to host Club Hours to maintain leadership.
 - Club Hour requirements can be substituted for route setting or other associated service hours

Proper Documentation:

Accident/Incident Reporting:

In the case of an injury, it is the responsibility of the OP Employee or Wall Leader to fill out an Accident Report immediately (same day) following the time of the incident. These reports should be filled out with a detailed account of the events and outcomes of the accident. Paper copies of the Accident Report can be found in the Rock Wall Binder. Accident reports should be submitted to OP professional staff.

Timesheets:

OP Employees will document their hours through RPI Self-Service Information Systems following the completion of their work hours. Hours that are not submitted on time may be subject to dismissal.

Wall Repairs:

If the wall needs to be repaired or installations are suggested for the rock wall (not including route setting or tightening holds), students should rely on requesting help from trained campus partners. Requests should be forwarded to the Assistant Director of Outdoor Programs so that they may be addressed.